



Noir Hysteria

Figures of Masculinity in Crisis in Contemporary Hollywood Cinema

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In *The Corrections*, the episode introducing Jonathan Franzen's failed English Professor, who will subsequently be charged with sexual harassment and fired from his job, is significantly entitled *The Failure*. The trouble begins when, in the final class in an introductory course on cultural studies, he tries to test his students' mastery of the critical perspectives to which he has introduced them, and does so by showing a video of a six-part ad campaign called „*You Go, Girl*.“ What he hopes they might have learned is a theoretical debunking of the video, aimed at deconstructing the false ideology of positive gender stereotyping revolving around the empowerment of women with breast cancer. Instead he finds that his students completely fall for the ideology and end up debunking him instead. His cynically cultural pessimism is an attitude they will not buy. On thinking through what went wrong during the class session, Chip finally comes to the following conclusion, which I have chosen to quote at length, because it raises the core issue at stake in discussing an alleged crisis in masculinity at the turn of the twenty-first century:

Melissa's accusations had cut him to the quick. He'd never quite realized how seriously he'd taken his father's injunction to do work that was 'useful' to society. Criticizing a sick culture, even if the criticism accomplished nothing, had always felt like useful work. But if the supposed sickness wasn't a sickness at all – if the great Materialist Order of technology and consumer appetite and medical science really was improving the lives of the formerly oppressed; if

*it was only straight white males like Chip who had a problem with this order – then there was no longer even the most abstract utility to his criticism. It was all, in Melissa's word, bullshit.*¹

¹ Franzen (2001),

45.

In the course of this episode, Melissa will seduce her professor, taking pity on his sexual obsessions, only to make him recognize that if anything is sick, then it is his way of treating his symbolic investiture – both as a lover and as a teacher. Her move into a position of symbolic power will prove to be concomitant with his loss of masculine authority.

If one looks at Hollywood mainstream cinema of the 90s with the critical gaze Chip tried but failed to teach his students, one does get the impression that it is particularly „straight white males“ who have a problem with the symbolic order, notably with their mandate as sons, fathers and husbands, as one also gains the impression that a cultural critique based on their superiority misses the mark. One might take Woody Allen's *Celebrity*, a comedy about the corrupt manners and morals of late 90s urban culture, as a case in point. In the final sequence of the film, Allen's alter-ego Lee, played by Kenneth Branagh, sits alone in a movie-theater, around him the stars and fans, who, like him, have come to watch the premiere of an independent art film. Exhausted from the gender troubles of his life, the failed writer stares at the screen, where, in the first scene of the film projected there, we see an airplane, tracing the word „help“ across the sky. In the gesture of the male hysteric, for whom everything revolves around his affliction and his anguish, our hero reads this as a clandestine message particularly meaningful to himself. After all, he had unexpectedly met his divorced wife Robin in the foyer of the theater and had seen reflected in her happiness, how hopelessly unhappy he was himself. If, at the beginning of *Celebrity*, he had wanted to separate from her, because he wanted to devote himself shamelessly to the adventures of life and art, notably to the beautiful women he kept meeting in his function as star-journalist, and to his ambitions to become the great american writer of the late 20th century, he has since come to recognize the futility and the vanity of both projects. Woody Allen cruelly depicts how much fate has caught up with his narcissistically wounded protagonist by virtue of the loop that connects this final scene of the film with its beginning. For *Celebrity* itself sets in with the appearance of the writing on the sky. Lee had been present during the filming of the scene, but had not taken note of the portentous message then, because he was, at that time, still assured of his masculine empowerment. Now, however, he is compelled to see

in it a description of his own hopeless situation. All his romances have failed, his effort at writing the great American novel has been thwarted as well. A representative of the generation of white men around 40, plunged into a deeply resilient mid-life crisis, he sits exhausted and spiritless, indulging in his own demise. Yet the unhappiness of Woody Allen's alter-ego appears to be particularly compelling precisely because his downfall runs parallel to the success of the woman he had initially cheated on. Judy Davis, who in *Husbands and Wives* had played a sexually inhibited urban neurotic, has transformed herself in the course of *Celebrity* from a poorly dressed school teacher to a radiant, successful T.V. star. Meeting Lee again at the film premiere she had pointed out to him the ironic shift in their fates. Fully aware that she had turned into precisely the type of woman she used to despise, she has to admit that she is now much happier. Precisely because she knows that her sudden happiness is accidental, she can also play with this new identity with gusto. For her, there is no question of a crisis in symbolic investiture.

That such a debunking of the straight white male, accompanied by the counter-figure of feminine empowerment, need not necessarily always lead to self-pity and self-indulgence, but rather to self-irony, is something Robbie Williams has compellingly demonstrated. In his controversial music video *Rock DJ*, he suddenly appears on the dance floor from a hole in the floor and, by pointing to his masculine virility, tries to win the attention of the girls, skating around him in circles. But even though this former member of one of the most successful boy groups persistently puts his body on display, the female dancers avert their gazes, absorbed completely by their movement and in each other. Robbie Williams begins to strip with determination, but only after he has ripped off his skin, his flesh and finally torn his organs out of his body, does his self-display have any effect. Reduced to a dancing skeleton, moving with the rhythm of the music, he catches the eye of the female D.J., who has finally chosen to pay attention to him. Now she is willing to descend from the Olympian heights of her control booth to the dance floor and rock with him. In this macabre enactment of the demontage of the male body one finds not only a witty refiguration of the conventional motif of death and the maiden, illustrating that, although she may be touched by death, the maiden still inhabits her living body. Rather, this video clip can also be seen as a culturally astute demontage of the male starbody. Afterall, the woman is interested in Robbie Williams' exposed body, however only after it has been stripped of its ostentatiously flaunted masculinity.

One might consider other refigurations of the male starbody in crisis, for example Bruce Willis' parodic subversion of the action hero in his *Die Hard* series, Russel Crowe's charismatic if ideologically murky reappropriation of the role of lonely war hero in *Gladiator*, or Tom Cruise's embellishment of his own wounded body in *Vanilla Sky*. If, in what follows, I will concentrate on two recent films, namely Chris Nolan's *Memento* and Ethan and Joel Coen's *The Man who wasn't there*, I do so because both films have recourse to the genre which above all others became famous for celebrating anxieties revolving around masculinity gone awry, namely *film noir*. As Vivan Sobchack comments, „it is now a commonplace to regard *film noir* during the peak years of its production as a pessimistic cinematic response to volatile social and economic conditions of the decade immediately following World War II.“ She argues that *film noir* can be seen as

*playing out negative dramas of postwar masculine trauma and gender anxiety brought on by wartime destabilization of the culture's domestic economy and a consequent 'deregulation' of the institutionalized and patriarchally informed relationship between men and women.*²

2 Sobchack (1998),

130.

Indeed, the heros of *film noir* repeatedly find themselves penetrating into the dark world of an urban war zone; into a disorienting, fascinating and at the same time threatening counter world of corruption, intrigue, betrayal and decadence, from which, in contrast to the war front they left behind, they can only escape by death. The sense of a paranoid universe *film noir* came to transmit, namely that its protagonists were fatefully entrapped in a disempowering world denying them all agency, must be seen in relation to the transitional, and politically instable, historical period ranging from America's entrance into the second world war in 1941 to the post war and cold war period lasting until the late 1950s. Particularly central to *noir's* sober view of American culture, trying to reassert a lost patriarchal order in peace time are, of course, the veterans returning both to the workplace and the family life they had left behind; not only because they found themselves confronted with women as the alleged „internal enemy,“ whom they had sought to escape from in the battle field in the first place. Rather, the impossibility of restituting the lost patriarchal order painted by *film noir* cinematically refigures the fact that the women to whom the war heros were returning had become economically independent during the war. Called upon by American politicians to „Give your job to GI Jo,“ they were compelled, often unwillingly, to return to the hearth and to motherhood. So that the idealized home

front, which war propaganda had installed as an ideology in the name of which the battle against the Axis Powers was fought, proved not only to be a mythic construct. More importantly, this allegedly felicitous home, and with it all family values bolstering masculine authority, proved to be a new site of contention and battle, no longer running between two cultures, but rather between American men and women.

A central anxiety, concerned with the postwar crisis in masculinity, thus emerged which enmeshed on the one hand the veterans' reclaiming their position as head of the family and as dominant breadwinner with, on the other hand, the working women's dissatisfaction, displaced from the workplace and once more confined to their domestic sphere. In what Vivian Sobchack calls scenarios of „domestic anxiety,“ feeding off the tension between attempts to „settle down“ and reclaim an idealized situation of prewar „stability,“ „security,“ and „loyalty“ and the social reality of insecurity, instability, and social incoherence of post war America, we find the character of the *femme fatale* emerging as a cinematic negotiation of the fears invoked by the successful, empowered and independent working woman.³ As Billy Wilder forcefully depicts in *Double Indemnity* (1944), forced to confine herself to the home, Phyllis Dietrichson (Barbara Stanwyck) will turn this allegedly felicitous space of safety into a war zone, where its straight down the line for both her and the man she has entrapped, forcing him to recognize his utter fallibility. Yet in *film noir* we also find the counter paranoia, namely the fact that the return of the disoriented veteran to a troubled domestic economy not only proved to be a period of precarious reintegration. Rather, they had brought home with them from the front another unresolvable antagonism, namely their traumatic war neurosis. Though postwar culture wanted to privilege the image of the valiant war hero over that of the psychically wounded soldier, the American public came to cultivate anxieties revolving around the question, what kind of men these veterans actually were; most importantly whether in peacetime they would be able to constrain the deployment of violence that had allowed them be successful at the battlefield, and concomitant with this, whether they

3 Sobchack (1998),

131.

1. Barbara Stanwyck.
Filmstill aus *Double Indemnity* von Billy Wilder (USA 1944).
Zuletzt gesehen am 01.05.02 unter:
www.culturefront.org/culturefront/magazine/99/fall/images/hardboiled.jpg.



would be able to carve out for themselves a space in peacetime America. *Film noir* thus offers homelessness, or rather the recognition that one can never be at home in this post-war world, and should accept this condition with humility, as the existential subtext of these somber narratives, for the world which the *noir* hero and heroine inhabit is radically dislocated, the fissures impossible to oversee, and all efforts at happy endings inevitably thwarted.⁴ As Dana Polan notes, the precarious homecoming of the war veteran, fraught with ambivalence and anxiety, is interlinked in the image repertoire of *film noir* with the way the imperatives of war have invested themselves „in a particular representation of home. At the extreme, the forties home is not simply a haven against the outside world but a separate world of its own, a vast act of the imagination.“ It becomes a self-enclosed environment, working rigorously „to close out the world of ambiguous interaction, of ambivalent meanings,“ even while proving to be „no more than a representation,“ grounded in nothing that assures its permanence or its invulnerability, „often only an untale fantasy.“⁵ In classic *film noir* home, and with it concepts of the happy nuclear family, thus emerge as a fragile and threatened entity. As Vivian Sobchak concludes, while insisting that „the intimacy and security of home and the integrity and solidity of the home front are lost to wartime and postwar America,“ these somber film scenarios celebrate the uncanny transiency of the dispossessed and the displaced;

*a perverse and dark response, on the one hand, to the loss of home and a felicitous, carefree, ahistoricity and, on the other, to an inability to imagine being at home in history, in capitalist democracy, at this time.*⁶

When *neo-noir* initially emerged in the 1980s, it gained critical interest particularly for the way the domestic anxiety it reinvoked brought about a significant refiguration of the *femme fatale*. The heros of these films are as seducible and as vulnerable as their predecessors, as unable to accept their symbolic mandate. In fact they often represent fallible representatives of the law, notable the police detective (Michael Douglas) in *Basic Instinct* (1991), whose proclivity towards violence gets him suspended from duty; the lawyer (Willem Dafoe) in *Body of Evidence* (1992), whose proclivity toward sado-masochism gets him to enter into lethal sexual games with his defendant, accused of having killed her husband; the schoolteacher (Matt Dillon) in *Wild Things* (1998), whose sexual ambivalence gets him involved in a clandestine affair with one of his students and makes him an easy target for her blackmail; or the young accountant (Peter Berg) in *Last Seduction* (1994), whose clueless naiveté makes him the perfect victim

4 MacCanell (1993).

5 Polan (1986), 253.

6 Sobchak (1998),
166.

for a woman, who, having robbed her husband of a huge amount of money, needs to get rid of him as well. Yet the heroines of most of these narratives experience a very different fate from the earlier version of the *femme fatale*. With the exception of *Body of Evidence*, the *noir* heroine of the late 20th century is able to break the law, to shamelessly abuse her vulnerable lover, only to have him go to jail or take the bullet in her stead, while she survives happily with all the money.

Chris Nolan's *Memento* (2001) suggests itself as a perfect example for the two sides of the equation defining a masculinity in crisis, with which I began my discussion, namely the correlation between feminine empowerment and masculine disempowerment. The protagonist, Leonard Shelby (Guy Pierce), who used to be an insurance agent in San Francisco, suffers from short term memory loss. After his home had been broken into, and his wife attacked by the burglars in their bathroom, he had gone to help her. One of the burglars, who may have killed his wife, had wounded him on the head, with the result that since the accident he knows everything about himself prior to this traumatic moment, but can retain no new memories. His everyday existence is comparable to a puzzle, which he must repeatedly find a coherent pattern for, notably by writing himself notes, taking polaroids of important places and people, and tattooing important messages to himself onto his body, pertaining to the death of his wife and the identity of her murderer. Significant about this scenario is that it is only his desire for revenge which endows viable meaning to the cryptic fragments of Leonard's existence. While oblivion repeatedly catches up with him, it is the perpetual effort at reconstructing a narrative about his identity, and concomitant with this about the identity of his wife's murderer, which gives him the energy to go on living. In the course of the film's own narrative, which is significantly told backwards, we discover that the man he killed in the first scene of *Memento* was his friend Teddy (Joe Pantoliano), who may be a rogue cop or simply a small time crook. In the scene of anagnorisis, prompting Leonard to kill this friend, he had claimed he had initially helped him find the man responsible for his wife's death. Owing to his short term memory loss, however, Leonard couldn't remember that he had been successful in his revenge. Thus Teddy was able to use him for his own



2. Guy Pierce. Filmstill aus *Memento* von Chris Nolan (USA 2001). Zuletzt gesehen am 01.05.02 unter: www.fantasyfilmfest.com/2001/df_conpix/film_pages/f_memento_01.jpg

sinister machinations, involving drug dealers and other petty criminals, repeatedly feeding his psychically vulnerable friend with false leads that would compel him to murder innocent men, because he mistook them for his wife's assailant.

Yet the narrative fascination of Chris Nolan's film hinges on the fact that *Memento* is exclusively focalized by a man who allegedly can make no new memories. Everything we are presented with must be treated as pure conjecture, revolving around a radical gap in knowledge, which is why it is fruitful to discuss the excessive production of fictions we are presented with in terms of male hysteria. Indeed, in his correspondence with Fließ, Sigmund Freud had come to coin the term „protective fiction“ (*Schutzdichtung*)⁷ so as to describe the resilient fantasy work of his hysteric patients. Given that at the time he was still arguing for a traumatic primal scene at the heart of all hysteric symptoms, the term's double meaning was significant, highlighting, on the one hand, the fact that hysteric fantasy work produces fictions, which protect the subject from traumatic knowledge it is unable to address directly. But, on the other hand, the term *Schutzdichtung* also gestures toward the fact that these psychosomatic symptoms serve to seal off this traumatic psychic material, and thus to insulate the subject from its effect. Two salient points emerge, once one reads Leonard's crisis in identity as a *noir* inflected expression of male hysteria. Firstly, like the war veterans of the postwar period, Leonard experiences a radical sense of homelessness. Not only was his actual home and family destroyed the night of the burglary, but, owing to his psychic disturbance, he can now no longer inhabit any place properly. Instead, in correlation to the vagabonding of his mind, he literally moves from one motel room to the next, unable to retain enough memories of any one place to make it an emotionally meaningful place of abode. Yet the significant counterpart to this homelessness is the fact that he resiliently holds onto a home romance in fantasy; indeed, as for so many of Freud's hysteric patients, one might claim for him, as well, that even while he can make no new memories, he actually suffers from an abundance of reminiscences pertaining to his lost wife and his lost home. Into the analeptic narration, leading from the killing of Teddy backwards to the killing of a drug dealer, whom his friend had convinced him to believe to be the murderer of his wife, Chris Nolan cuts scenes of memories Leonard has retained, pertaining to felicitous moments he shared with his wife. These are moments of plenitude that, in the sense of protective fictions, serve as antidotes to the fallibility of his actual existence.

7 Freud (1986).

But the trick Chris Nolan plays on us, reduplicating the hysteria of his *noir* hero with his own, utterly hysterical, cinematic narrative is that all these images of family happiness may be protective fictions in the sense of false memories. They may well be lies Leonard tells himself to insulate himself from a truth which would be more traumatic than his recollection of his wife's murder, the latter being something he clings to with such tenacity. His short term memory loss proves to be such a perfect example for hysteria, because its cause remains utterly cryptic. Although it is clearly the response to a domestic anxiety of sorts, what remains both unclear and unsolvable, is whether Leonard's wife was actually killed by one of the burglars (the version he himself privileges), whether he is, in fact, himself responsible for her death (the version Teddy confronts him with shortly before he is killed), or whether she simply died, in which case Leonard needs a dramatic protective fiction to shield himself from a contingency that would remain traumatic because forever unexplainable and thus also unaccountable for. Put another way, there is no doubt that *Memento* is concerned with a *noir* inflection of its hero's crisis in identity. Like his classic predecessors', Leonard's voice over incessantly tells us the story of his acute vulnerability, notably the way he clings to a story of trauma, as he relishes in relating the manner in which he valiantly battles with the psychic aftereffects of this traumatic experience. Yet there is great doubt as to the validity of the narrative Leonard presents us with, and, given the hysteric nature of the cinematic narration itself, unreliability is performed to excess. Not only may his wife have died a very different death. Rather the film leaves open the possibility that the entire crisis in masculinity Leonard performs with such gusto may be a fake as well.

For at the end of *Memento* a narrative strand emerges which at least opens up the possibility that Leonard's hysterical amnesia may be a psychic disturbance he is fully in control of; which is to say, not so much a sign of disempowerment as of the agency he has over his vulnerability. In the *peripeteia* of the film, where the final scene produces a turn from analeptic to proleptic narration, as we now are confronted with the conflict which will end in the killing with which *Memento* began, Teddy presents Leonard with a confession, in which he claims – though we, as the audience have no ground to take this as anything other than yet another protective fiction – that he has been using Leonard to commit killings that have nothing to do with the death of his wife, and that, in fact, Leonard was himself responsible for her death. His hope is that

Leonard will finally realize why it is necessary for him to leave Los Angeles as soon as possible. Yet as Leonard sits in the jaguar of the drug dealer he has just killed, he asks himself, „Do I lie to myself to be happy?“ and looking at his false friend, who is busy retrieving the car keys Leonard had thrust behind a bush upon leaving the crime scene, he responds to his own question, utterly self-confident, „In your case, Teddy, I will.“ Trusting that within more than a minute he will have forgotten that this was a conscious decision, he inscribes his polaroid of Teddy with the subtitle, „Don't believe his lies.“ At the same time he jots down Teddy's car plate number, and adds to it the note that this belongs to the man he is looking for. Incriminating Teddy, Leonard signs his death sentence, even while his

hysteria will allow him to abnegate all responsibility for this act. He can count on the absence of guilt just as he can count on the absence of any memories of this moment. Later, after he has had Nathalie (Carrie-Ann Moss), the former lover of the drug dealer he killed, check up on the owner of the car, he will be able to match up Teddy's polaroid with his name in seeming innocence, and add the sentence „He's the one, kill him.“ Yet Chris Nolan's *femme fatale* is seminal to the refiguration of the *noir* crisis in masculinity performed throughout *Memento* in yet another sense. Though she will use Leonard, once she has



3. Filmplakat zu *Memento* von Chris Nolan (USA 2001). Zuletzt gesehen am 01.05.02 unter www.hundland.com/posters/m/Memento-UK.jpg

realized who he is, to take revenge on the man who fatefully set up her lover, supporting the death plot against Teddy which Leonard had already decided upon while watching him through his jaguar window, she is also the one who gives a name to what is at the heart of Leonard's hysteria. After having handed over to him an envelope, containing the information that unequivocally shows Teddy to be the owner of the car, of which Leonard has convinced himself it belongs to the murderer of his wife, she explains to him: „You know what we have in common? We are both survivors.“ The extraordinary turn Chris Nolan thus gives to *film noir*'s exploration of a masculinity in crisis is that his hero feigns fragility, and undertakes his murderous quest, as a way of covering up his own resilience in the face of vulnerability. Indeed, in retrospect one remembers the distinct pleasure he has in pointing out his illness to whomever he meets, as there is clearly relief in the fact that he can do whatever he wants, because he can relinquish all responsibility after the deed is done. Chris

Nolan, of course, criticizes the invidiousness contained in Leonard's hysterical amnesia, even while also recognizing therein the resilient power of survival, notably when he has Teddy explain that Leonard is such a good killer because he has no memory, thus no consciousness and no guilt. He is the perfect killer machine, and one may well remember the cultural anxieties involving veterans returning home after World War II. For the perfidy of Leonard's hysterical appropriation of masculine fragility is that it is precisely this embrace of disempowerment that also makes up his enjoyment. Masochistic passivity emerges as the inversion of a masculine aggression gone awry, and a far more viable one to boot.

Joel and Ethan Coen's *The Man who wasn't there* also explicitly invokes *film noir* as its intertext, using the voice over of its protagonist, Ed Crane (Billy Bob Thornton), as a running commentary on how he came to blackmail his wife's lover so as to help finance a chain of dry cleaning places, only to end up killing him in self-defense, yet finding himself on death row for a murder he didn't commit. As we discover in the final sequence, this narratorial voice has a purpose. Ed Crane has been asked to use the time he has left in prison, to write an article for a men's magazine, describing his situation as a convicted man, which significantly revolves around the question those involved in his tragic case keep asking him, namely „What kind of man are you?“ Given that Ed Crane emerges from his story as the quintessentially modern man, devoid of all qualities, whose existence is grounded on a sense of absence, one might well speculate that his crisis is shaped in diametric opposition to Leonard's homelessness. For Ed Crane, living in the suburban world of Santa Rosa, California, there is too much home, even while he is only too aware of the emptiness inscribed in the home he shares with his wife Doris (Frances McDormand). Joel Coen's *noir* hero is a disaffected barber, who prefers to be silent while cutting the hair of his clients, and when he speaks he does so to give voice to the way his work forces him to take notice of the mutability of human existence. In a particularly poignant scene, he wonders aloud to himself about why hair keeps growing, pointing out that it continues to do so even after the body has died. Implicitly he is giving voice to his own predicament, because he appears to be a member of the living dead, his body alive although his spirit seems already to have faded. Indeed, in the course of the film, he will come to talk of himself as a ghost, i.e., as an uncanny double of himself not just because he has split himself in two, on the one hand

the convicted man, waiting to be executed, and on the other hand his former self, whose story he is narrating. Rather his is a spectral existence precisely because he wants to fade from the world he inhabits, has, in fact, already dissociated himself from this world, and is surveying both it and the symbolic position he occupies in it, as though he weren't actually a part of it. Although his home is still, nominally speaking, intact, he is as existentially homeless as Leonard is literally homeless.

But more important is the fact that in *The man who wasn't there*, domestic anxiety has less to do with any violent disruption of family peace, and in that sense also little to do with actual transgression. Indeed, his wife Doris is a rather listless adulteress, who is far more interested in promoting her professional position than enjoying clandestine sex, and better at bookkeeping than at seduction. Like the arch *femme fatale* Phyllis Dietrichson, however, she may be caught in the fatality of her circumstances, but she is neither sentimental nor deluded about them. In contrast to her husband, who seems to wander aimlessly into situations that will turn out to be disasters, she is fully aware not just of her actions, but also of her miscalculations, and willing to take full responsibility for them. In one scene, when she is driving back home with her husband from a family wedding, she suddenly realizes how stupid she was to believe she could count on another man to promote her in her job, and laughs out loud at herself, much as she will laugh again, when, having been arrested and placed in prison for the murder of her lover, her lawyer comes up with a scheme that might actually work in court and set her free. Indeed, like the classic *femme fatale*, she will prove her agency by deciding over her death, and in so doing debunking the fictions that those around her hold onto, so as to give meaning to their lives, notably about the intactness of the home, of family values and the gender roles they depend on. She will hang herself in prison, rather than return to the home which she knows has been destroyed forever, not just because her husband has confessed his murder to her, but also because she is bearing the murdered man's child. Indeed, one of the most chilling scenes in the film reveals the traumatic because unmitigatable absence inscribed into their marriage, and concomitant with this, Ed Crane's unremitting impotence. It is narrated as a flashback, in which Ed remembers a normal afternoon while his wife was still alive. We see him helplessly arguing with a man, trying to sell him gravel for his driveway, until Doris comes home, forcefully sends the bothersome salesman away, enters the house, gets herself a drink, and sits in the living room on the sofa, next to her husband, who has

come to join her. They have nothing to say to each other, and one might well speculate that this scene is so chilling precisely because it performs gender trouble in its purest form. The couple share no common ground of sympathy, no fantasies and no language, which would allow them to speak about their differences. What they share is indifference, masked as tolerance, to help them sustain an antagonism that can't be resolved.

If the mode of narration Chris Nolan privileges in *Memento* imitates Leonard's disturbance, by presenting a hysteric overabundance of possible fictions that results in competing versions of what happened, which contradict each other, it does so to perform the way this narrative excess is determined by a gap in knowledge. It is as impossible for us unequivocally to determine the truth behind Leonard's *noir* quest, as it is for this wounded and homeless man himself. Ethan and Joel Coen, in turn, perform the opposite, namely a mode of cinematic narration that veers toward radical dematerialization so as to imitate Ed Crane's proclivity towards self-obliteration; a move into silence, into the pure whiteness of the frame, into motionlessness. Although their gestures are diametrically opposed, with Leonard's excessive fictionality serving as the life-embracing counterpoint to Ed Crane's silent dissolution of the self, both films, thus my claim, are responses to, and cinematic refigurations of anxieties concerning masculine vulnerability. The solution we find in these two *noir* scenarios to domestic anxiety are either too many words or no words at all. If Leonard uses fiction to shield himself against the trauma of contingency, Ed wants to embrace pure absence, wants no agency, no desire. Yet, even though the one envelopes himself in lies, literally tattooing these on his body, while the other one wants to dissolve into silence, what both protagonists share is the sense that their crisis in symbolic investiture is linked to a crisis in the materiality of language. In this both films mark a return to the concerns of modernism, over and against a postmodern celebration of free signification, namely the equation of textuality with immateriality (Blanchot), with the death of the subject (Barthes), but above all with Heidegger's notions of the uncanny. Arguing that anxiety is comparable to an ontological queasiness that befalls the subject whenever he comes close to understanding the inherent instability of existence, Heidegger insists that the embrace of homelessness turns into existential recognition:

*In anxiety one feels 'uncanny.' Here the peculiar indefiniteness of that which Dasein finds itself alongside in anxiety, comes proximally to expression. As Dasein falls, anxiety brings it back from its absorption in the 'world.' Everyday familiarity collapses.*⁸

This move towards *Dasein* as a move away from an absorption in the worlds, from its noise, from the fictions that sustain it, is precisely what is at stake in Ed Crane's self-effacement. If Leonard insists on clinging to fictions veering towards yet never fully touching the trauma of his wife's death, and in so doing uses his hysteria to avoid both an absorption in the world as well as a full embrace of *Dasein*, Ed Crane offers a more radical response to the challenges posed to his masculinity. In answer to the question, „What kind of a man are you?“ he might well have replied, „the shadow of a man,“ who takes his crisis in symbolic investiture so literally as to shed all fictions pertaining to it. If, having traversed the trauma of vulnerability, Leonard discovers that he has nothing but language, albeit only fragments of messages, he needs to fit into coherent stories, to help him go on living, Ed Crane relinquishes all language, once he has come up with the one, coherent narrative of his life.

By explicitly presenting themselves as *neo-noir*, both films link our early twenty-first century cultural interest in anxieties revolving around masculinity with those revolving around representation, so as to address another postmodern malaise, namely its anxieties about authenticity. Leonard's obsession with lies, and Ed Crane's obsession with silence both critique the inadequacy of language, and implicitly argue that the trouble with masculine authority may have to do with another cultural trouble, namely the implausibility of authentic stories. *The man who wasn't there* not only takes as its location Santa Rosa, so as to pay homage to Alfred Hitchcock's *Shadow of Doubt*, a classic *film noir* in which a murderous uncle comes home, only to tarnish forever all fictions of small town happiness. Rather, the film also plays with resignifications of *Double Indemnity*. The rich wife of Doris' boss and clandestine lover, who actually owns the department store both work at, is called Ann Nirdlinger, and is thus a relative of Phyllis Nirdlinger, the *femme fatale* who marries rich, in order to call herself Phyllis Dietrichson, only to find that she must kill her husband if she wants his money. The county medical examiner, in turn, proves to be a relative of the murdered man from *Double Indemnity*, introducing himself as Mr. Dietrichson, before informing Ed Crane that his wife had been pregnant when she committed

suicide in prison. At the same time Joel and Ethan Coen's film exceeds mere citational homage, and it is their gesture of resignifications that ask to be taken seriously. Their *femme fatale* does cheat on her husband, but it isn't her lover who commits murder for her, but rather the husband who successfully takes revenge. While his act of violence brings with it the same sense of spectrality Walter Neff feels, the minute he accepts Phyllis Dietrichson's fatal call, given that in what is almost a direct quote from *Double Indemnity*, Ed Crane explains after hearing of Doris' death „it was like I was a ghost walking down the street,“ it is again the difference in the resignification that asks to be interpreted. Billy Wilder's Walter Neff will fight to the end to survive, even if it means killing the *femme fatale*, whereas Ed Crane fights to the end, so that he might finally disappear from a world he never felt at home in. Indeed, the discrepancies between the classic *noir* scenario and Ethan and Joel Coen's resignification offers a compelling answer to the impasse of postmodernity's crisis with representation. Even while their explicit usage of citation suggests that Ed Crane's story of a typical modern man, caught in the fictions of life and seeking to escape into immateriality, can not be told as his own story, indeed can only be told ironically, as a self-conscious refiguration of a pre-existing genre, the film decidedly moves beyond the cliché of textual freeplay; producing a compelling narrative shaped by silence, much as Leonard's celebration of fictional excess veers towards the only authentic expression of an ungraspable truth available to him.

Thus, while both films address anxieties revolving around masculine vulnerability, and do so by linking these scenarios to the impossibility of telling coherent, linear stories, they share none of the cultural pessimism one might find in more self-indulgent critics of masculinity gone awry. The feminine counter players to the straight white man, for whom the western cultural order is a problem, have agency precisely because the boundary between life and death for them is a concrete reality, not a question of signs; either, as is the case with Nathalie, designing the murder she needs to survive, or, as is the case with Doris, taking her life. At the same time both *Memento* and *The man who wasn't there* reintroduce real significance in an intelligent way that, rather than falling back on naive cultural nostalgia, offers a belief in fictions. There may be no authentic, original stories to tell, but there are stories that give voice to homelessness in an existentially crucial manner; namely as a condition, that, as MacCannell argues, teaches us humility. Indeed, I would go so far as to claim that cultural progress can be found in the shift both cine-

4. Barbara Stanwyck.
 Filmstill aus *Double Indemnity* von Billy Wilder (USA 1944).
 Zuletzt gesehen
 am 01.05.02 unter:
www.moderntimes.com/bab/di/di.jpg.



matic narratives undertake by no longer having recourse to a strategy of aversion, in which it is the *femme fatale* – her madness, her liminality and her death – over whose body issues of homelessness and lack of plenitude are negotiated that are actually constitutive for modern subjectivity as such. Embracing and embellishing the fact that not just the feminine subject but also the masculine one has always been in crisis may be seen as a moment of waking up, of breaking with narcissistic self-projections and accepting the alterity of the Other. It may be the moment where gender trouble turns into the recognition that fallibility is endemic to existence before and beyond gender. Accepting human fragility as a condition that can never be resolved, need not mean giving up fictions, on the contrary, it might, as is the case in *Memento*, prove to be the catalyst of incessant narrative production. But it does mean relinquishing illusions and delusions of masculine prowess, virility and plenitude. Which brings me back to Robbie William's skeletal body in *D.J. Rock*. For artists to invent stories about masculine heroes accepting their fallibility is what draws the sought for feminine attention – not the facticity of heroic deaths, but the far more disturbing one of everyday mutability. This is a moment of sobriety, but also one for hope.

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